

REPORT TO THE COMMUNITY 2025

PUBLIC MEDIA CONNECT



WELCOME

Dear Friends and Donors,

This has been a challenging year for all of us in public media. In July, we saw our federal funding rescinded, giving us only a three-month glide path to navigate the next chapter. The loss of federal support to CET and ThinkTV represented more than \$2.6 million – about 15 percent of our annual operating budget.

To make matters worse, we also lost in excess of \$500,000 in state funding overnight. That funding was a critical resource that supported our educational work with educators, students, and families.

But today, we still stand tall because of you. Our community came together — in financial support and advocacy — to remind us that we are an essential asset to families in Southwest Ohio as well as Northern Kentucky and Southeastern Indiana.

Thank you for your countless calls to legislators, attending our events, sharing our mission and speaking out on behalf of CET and ThinkTV. You rose to the occasion, allowing us to keep working.

Your voice truly matters.

The funding battle is far from over, but our strategies to reduce expenses and generate new revenue are already in motion, ensuring our good work can continue for the communities we serve.

Despite the distraction of lost funding, your public television stations continue to celebrate the rich culture and history of our region. Together, we've proven that community-driven media can endure — and thrive — even in difficult times.

As we look ahead, we invite you to stay engaged, share our mission, and continue supporting local public media. With your help, we will keep telling the stories that inform, inspire, and connect us all.

On behalf of our Board of Trustees and staff, we are pleased to share our annual report, reflecting on an impactful 2025.



Stephanie Amlung
Chair, Board of Trustees



Kitty Lensman
President & CEO

A handwritten signature in black ink that reads "Stephanie Amlung".

Stephanie Amlung
Chair, Board of Trustees

A handwritten signature in black ink that reads "Kitty Lensman".

Kitty Lensman
President & CEO

YEAR IN REVIEW



While the future of public media remains uncertain with the loss of federal funding, CET and ThinkTV have been able to continue our work on air, online and in the community thanks to the support of viewers, members and advocates like you. As we look back on 2025, even while making efforts to reduce costs, the year was packed with exciting content production, impactful educational work, inspiring community events and much more because of your support. **Thank you.**

We produced dozens of episodes and digital shorts of our regular shows, including *The Art Show*, *SHOWCASE with Barbara Kellar*, *Brick by Brick: Solutions for a Thriving Community*, *Rodney Veal's Inspired By* and *Stephanie's Recipe Journal*. We also premiered two special productions that were featured nationally by American Public Television - *Rick Steves' Europe: A Symphonic Journey* and *Jeffrey's Journey*.

For our over-the-air viewers, we launched ThinkTV16 Journey and ThinkTV14 Explore, making room for the 24/7 broadcast of The Ohio Channel in both Cincinnati and Dayton starting in January of 2026. We also worked with The Ohio Channel team to broadcast more local content from CET and ThinkTV across the state.

Our more than 20 community events brought together almost 2,000 members of our community, spanning all ages, backgrounds and interests. These events were not just an opportunity to share our work but to be an even deeper part of the community we all share. From "Be My Neighbor Day" events for kids and Super Saturday professional development days to screenings, trainings, field trips and trivia night, we had a wonderful year of events - big and small.

160
NOMINATIONS
60
RECOGNITIONS
SINCE 2010



Public Media Connect is the regional partnership between CET in Cincinnati, ThinkTV in Dayton and SOITA - the Southwestern Ohio Instructional Technology Association. Public Media Connect serves a regional population of 3.1 million people, with a regular household viewership of 1.5 million per month.

YEAR IN REVIEW

The Past & The Future

Last year marked the release of Ken Burns' *The American Revolution*, which not only inspired multiple community events, including partnerships with the Cincinnati Museum Center and Miami University as well as a history-focused trivia night, but also spurred the development of our own content. That included a long-form documentary, *This Moment in America*, as well as digital shorts and educational materials.

Reflecting on the connection between the past and the future, we produced our third installment of *Yom HaShoah: Remembering for Tomorrow - Survivors Stories*. This partnership between CET, The Nancy & David Wolf Holocaust & Humanity Center and the Cincinnati Ballet included six new stories as well as a video on "Engaging the Holocaust through Dance." *SHOWCASE with Barbara Kellar* also featured Cincinnati Ballet's "Our Story" with choreographer David Morse, ballet dancer Taylor Carrasco and Holocaust survivor Monique Rothschild.

The history theme continued with an encore broadcast of *Independent Lens* "WE WANT THE FUNK!" alongside our very own "From Dayton with Funk" celebration. We also held events with the

Creating Art About Art

While taking time to reflect on our community's role in peacemaking, *The Art Show* team also produced more than a dozen local features developed for multi-platform distribution, opened a new studio space at Front Street Studios in Dayton and continued the recorded and live production of the bi-weekly podcast, *Rodney Veal's Inspired By*. We also hosted two "Arts Breakfast" events in the spring and started two new blog series - "Arts Off 75" and "From the Producer." This season, *The Art Show* also included features on Ohio Heritage Fellows Sujatha Srinivasan and Susan Abramovitz made possible by the Ohio Arts Council.

Our other long-standing arts program, *SHOWCASE with Barbara Kellar*, continues to be the only program in Cincinnati featuring long-form discussions with arts and cultural leaders as well as people of note in our region. In 2025, Barbara discussed "Auschwitz: Long Ago, Not Far Away" with Elizabeth Pierce and Jackie Congedo, highlighted the new Cincinnati Symphony Orchestra Music Director Cristian Macelaru and much more.

National Aviation Hall of Fame and in conjunction with the 30th anniversary of the Dayton Peace Accords. As part of that anniversary, we hosted a live panel discussion, which we produced into *Dayton: City of Peace 2025* with companion stories from Bosnian refugees. The program educated viewers on the history of the Peace Accords and Dayton's role while discussing why the 2025 NATO Spring Parliamentary Assembly was hosted in Dayton, Ohio. The program also paved the way for additional features on *The Art Show*.



Above, from left: Producer Rodney Veal, Congressman Michael Turner, International Peace Museum Executive Director Alice Young-Basora, US History and Government Teacher Kevin Lydy, Director of Local Content Mark Lammers and Brick by Brick Producer Ann Thompson

We also produced *Rick Steves' Europe: A Symphonic Journey* in partnership with Rick Steves, Cincinnati Pops Symphony Orchestra and American Public Television, which premiered to national acclaim. We are currently developing the concert, which was recorded across three performances in front of more than 3,000 attendees, into online learning resources for educators and parents.



When asked if they would air *Rick Steves' Europe: A Symphonic Journey*, 336 out of 350 PBS stations said YES. Those broadcasts began in April 2025.



(From left: Production Assistant Derrick Smith, Producer Kaelin Hagler, Chief Content Officer Colin Scianamblo, Videographer Zach Kramer and Host Stephanie Amlung)

Let's Get Cooking

Lifestyle content has long found a home on PBS - from Julia Child to Bob Ross to Tom Silva. In 2025, *The Baking Journal* celebrated five years with a rebrand and a move to broadcast as *Stephanie's Recipe Journal* in September, airing just before *America's Test Kitchen*. *Stephanie's Recipe Journal* also gives us a chance to continue to get together for events like "Gin and Baking" in 2024 and "Bourbon and Baking" in 2025.

The popularity of our cooking and lifestyle programs also spurred multiple events, including a "25 Years with *America's Test Kitchen*" celebration and livestreams with both Jacques Pepin and the Milk Street Cooking School. We know PBS personalities - especially related to food - are a favorite for our community, so we're working to have more of those events in the future.

Where in the World is Our Education Team?

This year, our education team represented our stations at celebrations and events of all kinds in Cincinnati and Dayton. In Cincinnati, those events included the Hispanic Heritage Festival, International Friendship Day, Ezz Fest at Ezzard Charles Park and the annual Sanaa Festival with the Robert O'Neil Multicultural Arts Center. We made sure to join in on the holiday festivities with Easterland at The Neighborhood House, Winter Wonderland at The Neighborhood House, Toys in the Neighborhood with We EXCEL, Yani Collective and Product of the Project. We also attended local cookouts, block parties and even car shows with organizations like the Cincinnati Symphony Orchestra, The Community Builders in Avondale, Cornerstone Renter Equity in Over the Rhine, Colerain Council of Neighborhoods and Joseph Auto Group. Back-to-school season brought events with the Neighborhood House and Butler County Social Services, as well as educational institutions like Northwest School District and Princeton High School.

In the Dayton, we participated in a resource fair at the Salvation Army Dayton Kroc Center, attended career days at the Dayton Metro Library and Dayton Public Schools and shared career information at Sinclair Community College's Academic Re-Engagement & Career (ARC) Festivals. We also engaged with families during Optimist Day in the Park with Dor-Wood Optimist

Clubs, presented resources with moms to be and new mothers at the Creating Connective Relationships through Partnerships for Dayton's Babies conference at Wright State University. Over the summer, we partnered with The NEON in Dayton to present PBS KIDS films and, when back to school kicked off, we participated in a school resource event at Centerville's Primary Village. On Thanksgiving weekend, we even hosted a special Be My Neighbor Day event with the International Peace Museum.



Jobs Explained is a shorts-focused series that lives mainly on TikTok and Instagram. A public media-powered virtual career fair, the series is designed to connect local youth and young adults directly to education, training and job opportunities in their communities and beyond. You can find those accounts @swohiojobs_explained on YouTube and Instagram.

YEAR IN REVIEW

Meeting Community Needs

When it comes to our community, we spent 2025 finding ways to meet the needs of our region through content, programs and events. The first season of *Brick by Brick: Solutions for a Thriving Community* wrapped in the spring and the second season kicked off in the fall. Our team of multi-media journalists not only told dozens of stories, but also hosted and attended community events and panel discussions and continued to become part of the fabric of the stories in our community. Additionally, stories like *Jeffrey's Journey*, which follows a disabled adventure cyclist, reminded us of the power of the human spirit. That story, also distributed nationally by American Public Television, is expected to air on more than 250 local PBS stations throughout the country in 2025 and into 2026.

Our education team also worked to meet community needs, both through content development with programs like *American Graduate: Jobs Explained* and *Talking Jobs*, as well as by supporting students, families and educators with unique programs. We hosted 17 live, standards-based distance learning programs that brought virtual field trips, demonstrations and experiments directly into classrooms and we partnered with the National Aviation Hall of Fame Innovation Lab to create activities for classroom and family visits.

We invited students, donors, journalists and other members of our community to our studios for field trips, tours and discussions. We even held interactive events on topics like careers, green screen technology, stop-motion animation, storytelling and STEM.

Recognizing the importance of being in the community, we set up tables at local events, where we shared information about free resources from PBS and our local stations. By hosting “Pop-Up and Play” events in local neighborhoods, we helped limit transportation barriers to out-of-school time enrichment experiences. We also held “Be My Neighbor Day” open houses, a screening of “Bugs that Rule the World” with the Cincinnati Museum Center and the Queen City Pollinators Project and partnered with The NEON in Dayton to offer free summer film events. Our partnership with Omega CDC in the Hope Zone supported education, economic stability and wellness for families in our community.



Jeffrey's Journey won the 57th Public Media Award of Excellence for Topical Feature from the National Educational Telecommunications Association in September 2025. Public Media Awards recognize the finest work of public media stations across the country.

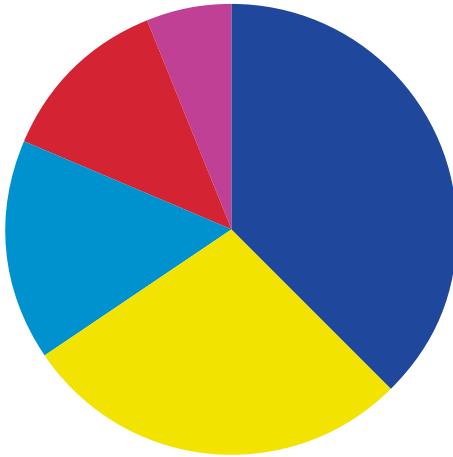


Talking Jobs is an educational video series we produce in partnership with the Broadcast Educational Media Commission and the Ohio Department of Education and Workforce. The series, available on YouTube, is designed to help career seekers explore job possibilities and career paths and is shared by teachers across the state.



We regularly hold station tours, giving community groups, students and donors a chance to peek behind the curtain of our productions.

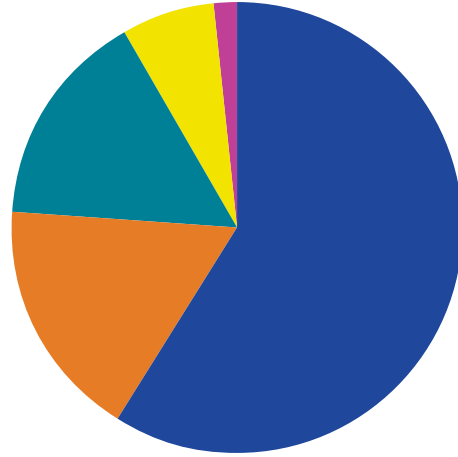
Total 2025 Revenue: \$16,469,816



- Community Funding 37.72% – \$6,212,026
- Earned 27.97% – \$4,606,809
- Corporation for Public Broadcasting Funding 15.87% – \$2,613,943*
- In-Kind Donations 12.36% – \$2,035,369
- State and County Funding 6.08% – \$1,001,669

*this includes the October 2024 CPB grant. With the federal defunding of public media, this is not income that will be recognized in 2025.

Total 2025 Expenses: \$15,221,686



- Local Content, Programming, Distribution and Education Services 58.99% – \$8,979,866
- Promotion and Marketing 17.17% – \$2,613,533
- General and Administrative 15.60% – \$2,374,361
- Depreciation 6.81% – \$1,036,928
- Fundraising 1.43% – \$216,998

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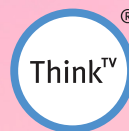
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